

THE KARAT EFFECT

NO BIG DEAL He has singlehandedly stalled the Indo-US nuclear deal. Even Sonia Gandhi's dinner diplomacy that had worked so well on his predecessor could not sway Karat. Despite Nandigram, he is not ready to compromise his ideology for power and has been consistent in his stand that it will either be the deal or the Government.

THE PRESIDENTIAL STAKES If it hadn't been for the Left, the Congress would have installed Shivraj Patil in Rashtrapati Bhavan. Karat rejected four cabinet ministers before he okayed Pratibha Patil's name. Having made the Congress sweat it out, he then proceeded to install his own candidate Mohammad Hamid Ansari as vice-president. Such is Karat's sway over the UPA that there was not a murmur of objection even though many felt that the post should go to a Congressman.

FOR THE PEOPLE The Congress had planned to impose President's Rule in Uttar Pradesh in February last year after the Supreme Court disqualified 13 BSP MPs for defecting to the Samajwadi Party. The UPA had even convinced BJP to support this somewhat controversial decision. But Karat refused point blank to endorse this move and the Congress had to abandon its plans.

REFORMS ON THE BACKTRACK After the rollback of the BHEL disinvestment, the Government was forced to abandon its plans of disinvesting 13 profit-making PSUs including GAIL, ONGC and SAIL. Karat is against plans to allow foreign capital into multibrand retailing, insurance and banking, and has stalled the modernisation of Kolkata and Chennai airports.

SIPRA DAS



GUARDIAN OF ENGELS: Karat at a CPI(M) rally in Delhi

Ramadoss found it difficult to get the Parliament to approve his legislation for getting rid of All India Institute of Medical Sciences Director P. Venugopal, Karat came to his rescue.

As party boss, Karat marks a cultural shift from his predecessors, especially Harkishen Singh Surjeet, who was a master of manipulation in the back rooms of power. Unlike some of his comrades, he refuses to be dazzled by the Dynasty. In his ideological absolutism, Karat is perhaps closer to EMS. No other Marxist has earned so many headlines for the party. A Google search for Prakash Karat yields almost 75,000 results. The formidable Karat edifice is built on the twin pillars of consistency and independence. His ideological antiquity may take India backward, but his personal integrity is impeccable—and the UPA finds it dangerous.

It is late evening and lesser apparatchiks have left the party headquarters. Only a corner room on the second floor is lit. A hot air blower breaks the silence. The chief is still at work. As the smog thickens outside his window, he is tempted to read the latest Ian Rankin, but the approaching party conference in Ganganagar, Rajasthan, gets preference. It is getting dark and some retired babus are waiting for a darshan. He puts on a black blazer over a moss green sweater and walks out, wiping the dust off his spectacles. Class enemies better clear out of Karat's sight.

with Shankar Aiyar